

RELIGIOUS PLURALISM AND THE PROBLEM OF ABSOLUTE TRUTH

FOUR AXES OF DIVERSITY → EXCLUSIVISM-INCLUSIVISM-PLURALISM → JOHN HICK → VEDĀNTIC MODELS → JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS → TOLERANCE AND RELIGIOUS FREEDOM

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g9 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

STAGE 00FOUR AXES OF DIVERSITY

FOUR AXES OF DIVERSITYRELIGIOUS DIVERSITY OCCURS ALONG FOUR AXES TRUTH:CONTRADICTORY DOCTRINAL CLAIMS SALVATION:WHO CAN ATTAIN LIBERATION/SALVATION?EPISTEMIC STATUSARE OTHERS REASONABLE/JUSTIFIED?CIVIC STATUSWHAT FREEDOM AND EQUALITY ARE OWED?

RELIGIOUS DIVERSITY OCCURS ALONG FOUR AXES truth: contradictory doctrinal claims salvation: who can attain liberation/salvation?

epistemic status: are others reasonable/justified?civic status: what freedom and equality are owed?PLURALISM can answer one axis without answering all tolerance is a political/moral practice

SOURCE / DOCTRINEARGUMENT / MECHANISMImplication / Verdict

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Pluralism must answer four distinct questions—truth, salvation, coexistence and epistemic humility—rather than treating social tolerance as proof that all doctrines are true.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Pluralism must answer four distinct questions—truth, salvation, coexistence and epistemic humility—rather than treating social tolerance as proof that all doctrines are true.

STAGE 01EXCLUSIVISM-INCLUSIVISM-PLURALISM

ONE TRADITION ALONE HAS SAVING TRUTHONE NORM IS FINAL, BUT GRACE/TRUTH OPERATES BEYOND EXPLICITMULTIPLE TRADITIONS ARE VALID RESPONSES/ROUTES TO ULTIMATE REALITY STRENGTHSEXCLUSIVISM PRESERVES DETERMINATE TRUTH; INCLUSIVISM WIDENS SALVATIONPLURALISM EXPLAINS DIVERSITY AND SUPPORTS HUMILITY COSTSPATRONISING ABSORPTIONFLATTENING REAL CONTRADICTIONS EACH MODEL MUST STATE TRUTH CRITERION

EXCLUSIVISM: one tradition alone has saving truth

INCLUSIVISM: one norm is final, but grace/truth operates beyond explicit membershipPLURALISM: multiple traditions are valid responses/routes to ultimate reality strengths: exclusivism preserves determinate truthinclusivism widens salvation

SOURCE / DOCTRINEARGUMENT / MECHANISMImplication / Verdict

MECHANISM / VERDICT — (Recommended opening definition): Exclusivism reserves decisive truth or salvation for one tradition, inclusivism admits truth elsewhere under one fulfillment, and pluralism treats multiple traditions as independently valid responses to ultimate reality.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: (Recommended opening definition): Exclusivism reserves decisive truth or salvation for one tradition, inclusivism admits truth elsewhere under one fulfillment, and pluralism treats multiple traditions as independently valid responses to ultimate reality.

STAGE 02JOHN HICK

JOHN HICKTHE REAL AN SICH (NOUMENAL, BEYOND FULL CONCEPTUAL CAPTURE)PERSONAL REPRESENTATIONSGOD, ALLAH, ĪṢVARANON-PERSONAL REPRESENTATIONS BRAHMAN, NIRVĀNA, EMPTINESS RELIGIONS ASSESSED BY TRANSFORMATION FROM SELF-CENTREDNESSKANTIAN DISTINCTION EXPLAINS DIVERSITY WITHOUT DECLARING ALL PROPOSITIONS IDENTICALHICK IMPOSES A META-THEORY: THE REAL BECOMES UNKNOWNABLE; TRANSFORMATION

THE REAL AN SICH (noumenal, beyond full conceptual capture) culturally shaped human responses

personal representations: God, Allah, Īṣvara non-personal representations: Brahman, nirvāna, emptiness religions assessed by transformation from self-centredness to Reality-centrednessKANTIAN distinction explains diversity without declaring all propositions identical objections: Hick imposes a meta-theory

SOURCE / DOCTRINEARGUMENT / MECHANISMImplication / Verdict

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Hick explains religions as culturally mediated responses to the Real, but the unknowability of the Real threatens to make the hypothesis unverifiable and covertly privileged.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Hick explains religions as culturally mediated responses to the Real, but the unknowability of the Real threatens to make the hypothesis unverifiable and covertly privileged.

STAGE 03VEDĀNTIC MODELS

VEDANTIC MODELSONE BRAHMAN; DIFFERENCES BELONG TO EMPIRICAL STANDPOINTMANY PATHS MAY PREPARE FOR NON-DUAL KNOWLEDGEREAL PLURALITY WITHIN BRAHMAN'S UNITY, DEVOTION TO PERSONAL GODDIVERSE RELIGIOUS PATHS CAN REALISE ONE ULTIMATEABSOLUTE-TRUTH PROBLEM IF ALL VIEWS ARE PARTIAL, IS "ALL"REPLY REQUIRES STANDPOINT DISCIPLINE, NOT EFFORTLESS EQUIVALENCE OF INCOMPATIBLE

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Vedantic pluralism distinguishes one ultimate reality from diverse conceptual and devotional approaches, but unity must not erase genuine doctrinal contradiction.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Vedantic pluralism distinguishes one ultimate reality from diverse conceptual and devotional approaches, but unity must not erase genuine doctrinal contradiction.

STAGE 04JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS

JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESSREALITY HAS MANY ASPECTSEACH FINITE STATEMENT ARISES FROM A STANDPOINTPREDICATE CONDITIONALLY — IN A CERTAIN RESPECT PLURALIST USERIVAL RELIGIONS MAY DISCLOSE DIFFERENT ASPECTS WITHOUT EXHAUSTIVE POSSESSIONEPISTEMIC HUMILITY + NON-VIOLENCE IN JUDGEMENT LIMITCONTRADICTIONS ARE RECONCILED ONLY IF RESPECTS GENUINELY DIFFERSYĀDVĀDA CANNOT SIMPLY PRONOUNCE EVERY DOCTRINE TRUE IN THE

ANEKĀNTAVĀDA: reality has many aspects

NAYĀVĀDA: each finite statement arises from a standpointSYĀDVĀDA: predicate conditionally — in a certain respect pluralist use: rival religions may disclose differentpossession strength: epistemic humility + non-violence in judgement limit: contradictions are reconciled only if respects

SOURCE / DOCTRINEARGUMENT / MECHANISMImplication / Verdict

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Anekāntavāda (doctrine of many-sided reality) and nayavāda (doctrine of partial standpoints) justify humility about perspectives without implying that contradictory propositions are simultaneously true in the same respect.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Anekāntavāda (doctrine of many-sided reality) and nayavāda (doctrine of partial standpoints) justify humility about perspectives without implying that contradictory propositions are simultaneously true in the same respect.

STAGE 05TOLERANCE AND RELIGIOUS FREEDOM

TOLERANCE AND RELIGIOUS FREEDOMREFRAIN FROM COERCION DESPITE DISAGREEMENT RESPECTRECOGNISE EQUAL STANDINGRECIPROCAL REASON-GIVING FREEDOMBELIEF, PRACTICE, CHANGE OF RELIGION, NON-BELIEF, ASSOCIATIONLIMITS COERCIONHARM TO RIGHTS MAY BE REGULATED BUT OFFENCE OR

TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing

dialogue: reciprocal reason-giving freedom: belief, practice, change of religion, non-belief, associationLIMITS coercionharm to rights may be regulated but offence or theological falsity alone is not sufficient

SOURCE / DOCTRINEARGUMENT / MECHANISMImplication / Verdict

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Religious freedom protects belief, practice, change and non-belief, but public restriction is justified only by neutral, proportionate protection of rights and order.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious freedom protects belief, practice, change and non-belief, but public restriction is justified only by neutral, proportionate protection of rights and order.

STAGE 06CONFLICT, UNIFICATION AND DEEP DISAGREEMENT

CONFLICT, UNIFICATION AND DEEP DISAGREEMENTCONFLICT SOURCESEXCLUSIVE REVELATIONSACRED HISTORYGRIEVANCE RESPONSESCOMMON ETHICAL CORECOMPARATIVE THEOLOGYLEGAL NEUTRALITY

CONFLICT SOURCES: exclusive revelation

sacred historygrievance responses: syncretismcommon ethical core

SOURCE / DOCTRINEARGUMENT / MECHANISMImplication / Verdict

MECHANISM / VERDICT — DEEP DISAGREEMENT persists because standards of evidence are tradition-shaped humility != relativism: give reasons, admit fallibility, seek overlap, preserve dissent objections to pluralism: self-refuting, imperial meta-theory, doctrinal dilution reply: modest pluralism can defend equal civic respect without equalising every truth claim.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Deep religious disagreement persists because evidence is interpreted through rival frameworks, yet rational dialogue remains possible through internal critique, shared reasons and epistemic humility.

STAGE 07PYQ ANSWER SPINE

PYQ ANSWER SPINEDEFINE AXISMAP EXCLUSIVISM/INCLUSIVISM/PLURALISMEXPLORE HICK EXACTLYCOMPARE ADVAITA/RĀMAṆUJA/JAIN ANEKĀNTATEST ABSOLUTE-TRUTH OBJECTIONMOVE FROM METAPHYSICAL DIVERSITY TO TOLERANCE/FREEDOM WITH LIMITSQUALIFIED CONCLUSION

DEFINE axis → map exclusivism/inclusivism/pluralism → explain Hick exactly → compare Advaita/Rāmaṇuja/Jain anekānta → test absolute-truth objection → move from metaphysical diversity to tolerance/freedom with limits → qualified conclusion → CLOSE: defensible pluralism is neither "all religions say the same" nor relativism

SOURCE / DOCTRINEARGUMENT / MECHANISMImplication / Verdict

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Pluralism need not deny absolute truth; it denies exhaustive possession of truth by any finite perspective and therefore supports a bounded, non-relativist openness.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Pluralism need not deny absolute truth; it denies exhaustive possession of truth by any finite perspective and therefore supports a bounded, non-relativist openness.

EXTRASUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENTADVANCED-DOSSIER RECONCILIATION — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]DOCTRINE STATEMENTEXCLUSIVISM MAKES ONE TRADITION'S DECISIVE TRUTH/SALVATION CLAIM UNIQUELY VALIDINCLUSIVISM GRANTS TRUTH OR SALVATION BEYOND IT WHILE INTERPRETINGEXCLUSIVISM APPEALS TO DETERMINATE REVELATION AND NON-CONTRADICTIONINCLUSIVISM ADDS UNIVERSALITY OF DIVINE GRACE WHILE PRESERVING NORMATIVEPRESUPPOSITION, CAUTION

OPTIONAL SOURCE WITNESSADVANCED OBJECTIONCOMPARATIVE NUANCE

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.